



As silent reading chapters get a second wind, find company in between pages **P2**

WHY SUNDEEP LOOKS FORWARD TO SIGMA **P4**

PHOTOS: SHIVARAJ S



Niharika NM

Popular content creator and actor Niharika NM acts as composer-actor Thaman's love interest in *Idhayam Murali*. Even after acting in several released and yet-to-be-released titles, she says she can never feel at home in the entertainment industry. "If anyone says they feel at home here, they are lying. It's something you do as a job. You roll with the punches, and you take one day at a time. But it's an interesting journey to take," says Niharika.

In an earlier interview, she had noted how she tries to keep her surroundings familiar, "so that it doesn't spiral out of place". But acting demands that she inhabit unfamiliar places and become unfamiliar people, and that can get a bit daunting, she confesses. "Contrary to my social media persona, I am an ambivert. So I do struggle with being 'on' all the time. But I have figured it out. If I want to stay quiet, I just stay quiet. If I feel chatty, I am chatty. I don't try anymore. I am exhausted."

Of late, we have seen many content creators and YouTubers try their hand at acting. While her experience in content creation may not help her gauge a project, Niharika says it certainly helps her market a film. "I know how to help push a film based on what it is, without it necessarily being in my style."

Those who have consumed Niharika's content would know

how her Reels – though they seem like rants – are well thought out; she takes a quirky idea and tries to push it to its extreme. So one wonders if Niharika has ever felt like leaning into the writer in her. "I am working on something. It's long format, and not for Instagram or YouTube," reveals the actor, who recently teased her upcoming Hindi debut co-starring Raghav Juyal.

Given the waves of nostalgia *Idhayam Murali* hits us with, one wonders if Niharika has a favourite '90s or 2000s romance film she would love to replicate today. "A lot of those films are great to rewatch, but you can't make them now because there are so many politically incorrect things in them," says the actor. "I would love to replicate so many of Shah Rukh Khan sir's films, like *Kuch Kuch Hota Hai*, but it might start a lot of other narratives. So I don't know if we could replicate the magic of the '90s and 2000s, but I would love to see someone do it."



Preity Mukhundhan

Preity Mukhundhan plays one of the love interests of Atharvaa. "It's a coming-of-age film about the life of a shy boy, the people he meets and falls in love with," says Preity, adding how her character travels throughout the story. "She is smart, speaks her heart out, and stands up for herself."

The actor notes how producer-director Aakash ensured the whole process was collaborative, especially since the film boasts an extensive ensemble featuring the likes of Fahadh Faasil, Natty, Thaman, and Anju Kurian, among others. "Right at the beginning, he told us that this project would be collaborative. And the way he directed us was also very breezy."

Preity, meanwhile, is in the limelight for her stellar action turn in *Blast* which refreshingly refrains from making its female action hero a mere gender-swapped stereotype. "I like that my character's fighting ability was given a solid backstory. I am glad that this was not something like 'she is raging because she went through abuse.' She is a normal girl brought up with empathy, and she is confident because she knows how to defend herself."

One however, wonders if this need to have a backstory is something that is only relegated to women heroes. "Yes, but a backstory grounds the story in reality. And people will feel more relatable, because the idea is that she is one amongst us," says the actor.

Preity has quite a few projects in the pipeline, including a Tamil survival thriller. "If a good writer comes my way, I would love to do a film like *Kill Bill*," she signs off.

Bhuvanesh Chandar
bhuvanesh.chandar@thehindu.co.in

It has been 35 years since the late actor Murali became the silver-screen symbol of unrequited love for Tamil society. His film *Idhayam*, co-starring Heera, told the story of the tribulations that a man experiences in pursuing his love for a college mate. Even though the idea of romance and unrequited love has since changed in life and on screen, the

Kathir-directed film has continued to blaze in our hearts thanks to Ilaiyaraaja's stellar album. And now, in 2026, 'Idhayam Murali' is once again promising to steal our hearts – and no, we are not talking about a re-release. Murali's son and popular actor Atharvaa is headlining the coming-of-age film, *Idhayam Murali*, helmed by producer-director Aakash Baskaran. Starring as the female leads of the film are Kayadu Lohar, Preity Mukhundhan, and Niharika NM.

Excerpts:

STEPOUT



Independent, unplugged

Permanent Vacation is a new live music show by Metal Chennai celebrating independent artistes and the passion that drives them beyond everyday life. Hosted at The Spotted Deer, the inaugural edition helps discover original music and experience live performances by three of Chennai's independent acts – Stevie, BIGSAM, and Spotlight – back after a hiatus. @Hotel Palomar, ECR. On July 18, 6.15pm onwards. Tickets, starting at ₹750 at outworld.fanpit.live.



Colours in transition

Sunrise to Sunset is a group exhibition by artists Hari Das, Harini Kumar, and Shaiba Rajesh, organised in collaboration with SOUL and Artworld – Sarala's Art International. KN Hari Das's body of work explores light, atmosphere and the passage of time, and traces the quiet journey of a fisherman's day, using minimalist compositions to evoke the changing moods of the sea from dawn to dusk. Artist Harini Kumar's paintings are about the everyday activities of people – either by the shore or in the shade of trees. Shaiba Rajesh's paintings honour the quiet strength of women whose lives are deeply connected to the sea. @Artworld – Sarala's Art International, Teynampet. Between July 9 and 11, from 11am to 6pm. For details, call: 9840850839.



Ushering in Jaipur

After a three-year hiatus, the brand Cottons Jaipur returns to Chennai with a week-long showcase of its latest collection. Known for its traditional craftsmanship and contemporary design, the showcase will feature a wide selection of kurtas, dresses, mix-and-match separates, farshi salwars, dupattas and coordinated sets. @Saumya, Sterling Road, Nungambakkam from July 13 to 19, between 10am to 7.30pm.

S Poorvaja
poorvaja.sundar@thehindu.co.in

There are over 60 women and one man, dressed in black athleisure of every kind, warming up on a Sunday afternoon at The Pole Camp's ECR studio. Anusha Swamy, pole artiste and founder, is checking to see if the poles fitted across the studio floor and ceiling are in alignment. "There might be nerves, so let us dance it out," says Mridula Joseph, and everyone breaks into a dance as Shakira's 'Hips Don't Lie' plays over the speakers.

Then, a rehearsal begins. All of them move with ease, graceful on the floor and fluid on the poles. For every breathtaking spin, every move that has some performers suspended upside-down, the others applaud.

The Chennai-based pole dancing school is gearing up for its first public showcase, *Becoming*, at Sir Mutha Venkatasubba Rao Concert Hall on August 16. Envisioned as an elaborate production and not as a pole show, *Becoming* will be based on the *navarasa* or the nine emotions, and

Pole perfect

Chennai's The Pole Camp takes the stage with *Becoming*, a thematic showcase highlighting fluidity and emotion

will have 64 students present thematic, choreographed pieces with the pole, onstage.

Anusha, who founded the studio nearly five years ago, says that when things started, she expected pole to thrive in Chennai as a fitness activity. "It did. But given how I am a dancer myself, I



realised that the dance is what makes this so interesting. I slowly began to introduce choreography lessons and saw how much my students enjoyed it even though many of them haven't danced before," she says.

Choosing to base *Becoming* on the *navarasa*, Anusha says, was the result of a roller-coaster of emotions she felt after a dental surgery. "In our 30s, somehow everyday feels like a complex mix of these multiple emotions. We go through this not just with life, but with pole as well. There is the initial fear to try it out, the happiness and exhilaration of getting it right, the courage to experiment and do better," she says.

Her background as a film choreographer and a classical dancer, Anusha says, helped her find meaning in each piece she set out to choreograph. "Pole might be extremely physical, but there are certain movements that lend

Spin cycle Anusha Swamy. KUNAL DASWANI

themselves to each emotion... you feel a sense of happiness, sadness or even love," the artiste says.

Choreographed over eight weeks by Anusha and her team, the performers are a mixed group; there are students, doctors, entrepreneurs, artists, corporate employees and more, with the youngest performer being seven and the oldest, in their mid-to-late-40s.

"For me, it has been about building a community, a safe space for women to be confident in their bodies. Many of them begin wondering if they are strong enough for this, but soon discover the joy that it brings to them, and in the process, fall in love with learning. The Pole Camp is a space now where one does not need to be worried, or feel conscious about who is watching them or if they are being judged," Anusha says.

While pole dancing might have taken off as something women turn to for fitness, and to find joy in movement and community, Anusha also emphasises on the history of how it evolved.

"One cannot erase history. Pole

dancing exists today because strippers were the first to do it, and that allowed women around the world to take it up and make it their own. It's evolved into many different forms, but that history remains," she says. "I do not like when 'stripping' is used as a derogatory term and find this implication that one form of pole is better than the other, problematic."

At present, The Pole Camp is functioning out of studios in Harrington Road and ECR, and a bigger studio in ECR is now in the offing. Anusha points to how Chennai has been very welcoming of all kinds of dance; be it pole, heels or a host of different forms.

"I have barely seen negative comments online on our videos, and have probably only seen a couple of negative comments about myself. This feels like a good sign," she adds.

Becoming, will be staged at Sir Mutha Venkatasubba Rao Concert Hall on August 16 at 6.30pm. Tickets available on www.thepolecamp.com.



How good is your flow

Rap at the Victoria Public Hall?

At Multiculture, catch some of the freshest voices in Tamil rap take part in epic battles and masterclasses that teach young musicians how to produce their own verses

Sanjana Ganesh
sanjana.g@thehindu.co.in

Are you ready to see a 12-year-old rapper spit fire on stage? You should be. At the second edition of Multiculture on July 19, an amalgamation of sub-genres will

come together at the hallowed halls of Victoria Public Hall to teach Chennai a thing or two about rap. Among the young men on stage will be Aydin Flow, a school-going rapper, who Ofro, the founder of Atticulture and the organiser of the event, met at a cypher at Anna Nagar Tower Park several months ago. Other artistes include Kelithe, 808Krsna, Hippiie Writer, Kaadi, Vaasi, Urban Tozha, and Tamizh Aadhavan – all of whom Ofro met through his Discord community and park meet-ups. “People from all over Tamil Nadu are coming and we

Battle cry (Top) Scenes from the previous edition of Multiculture; (left) Ofro and rappers signed to Atticulture. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



have been bombarded with ticket requests. The ultimate showdown, an event where some of Tamil rap’s freshest voices will be on stage, has already sold out,” informs Ofro, adding that there is a whole community of young rap voices from all parts of the State South of Chennai. “The slang, expressions, and meter of the rap is fundamentally different, meaning that there is an array of talent to look at,” he says.

Ofro was an early entrant in the rap space. Back in 2019 when he and Tamil rap star Arivu collaborated on their first ever independent project, the two took to Chetpet Eco Park and began performing their music for random visitors. “Back then, there was no real ecosystem to distribute our music or even claim a voice. The park was where we found our first listeners and another set of talent, including Asal Kolaar. The reason why people are clamouring for tickets is because they understand the kind of success that people like Arivu, Asal Kolaar, and Kelithe have seen. Considering that there will be reps (representatives) from other record labels, it is likely to be useful for a lot of the talent that comes on,” he says.

Ofro says that the reason they picked Victoria Public Hall is because it is an unlikely venue for a rap stage. That and the fact that they needed a venue bigger than Medai-The Stage, where their first edition happened a little over a year ago. “You might think it is an odd venue but this is where the first film was screened in Chennai, isn’t it,” he asks.

He adds that besides the main rap showdown that is to take place, Ofro is intent on getting better producers onboard, especially since he is one himself. It is why they are hosting a masterclass with Rupendar Venkatesh (who goes by Ruby) and Akash Shrivani, who have independently worked with the likes of AR Rahman, Hanumankind, Anirudh Ravichander, and Santhosh Narayanan, using their own unconventional and hard-hitting approaches to the art of mixing and mastering. There will also be a live podcast taping called Fryday Night Live with content creator Sameeha, who goes by potatoface on Instagram, and a curated screening of music videos that promise to be wild.

“Some gold-standard artistes are coming from the most unassuming places in Tamil Nadu. We want to shine light on this already existing slate of talent,” he says.

Multiculture is on July 19 at Victoria Public Hall starting at 11.30am. For tickets, log onto district.in

Too many cooks

Do cooks lead double lives and wear superhero capes at night? Find out at this year’s edition of The Little Theatre’s Little Festival

Elsa Sunny
elsa.sunny@thehindu.co.in

When the fate of the world hangs on a secret recipe, five eccentric cooks – Capsi, Souffle, Macaroni, Milo and Idli – step up to save the day.

As The Little Theatre raises the curtain on the 15th edition of The Little Festival, audiences can sneak a peek into the lives of *The Kooks*. Carrying the philosophy of clowning at its heart, this group of bumbling, wacky cooks transforms the kitchen into a playground where absolutely anything is possible. “*The Kooks* is a celebration of human imagination when it is free from the limits of what we think is possible,” says Krishnakumar Balasubramanian (KK), artistic

director, The Little Theatre.

This year’s edition of Little Festival, from July 12 to July 17, features two productions – *The Kooks: Sunny Side-Up* and *Giant’s Table* – at the Museum Theatre in Egmore.

The South Korean production, *Giant’s Table*, is an interactive play that uses media imaging technology to transform an ordinary table into a giant’s table. The play is suitable for audiences aged six and above.

“Our focus has been to present exceptional performances from Korea across a South Indian circuit, to connect meaningfully with a large network of school children, their parents and teachers,” says

Kitchen classics Cast of the play *The Kooks*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Rathi Jafer, director, InKo Centre.

A physical theatre play, *The Kooks* is a slapstick comedy featuring spectacular stunts, dance, and special effects, or, as its creator KK would put it, a “cartoon coming to life in spectacular fashion”.

Built around a theme of celebrating human imagination and working together, *The Kooks* is a story set in a kitchen. “When we thought about what brings people together, we realised there is nothing better than food. And so we set the story in a kitchen,” says KK.

The 2026 edition of *The Kooks* is also the directorial debut of Praveen Gunasekaran, who also plays one of the central characters in the play. Deepthie Orintelu, who plays a key role in the feature film *Gatta Kusthi* 2 appears as the dessert sous chef in the play. The cast also includes actors like Santhosh Kumar, Dinesh Subbiah and Loganathan J.

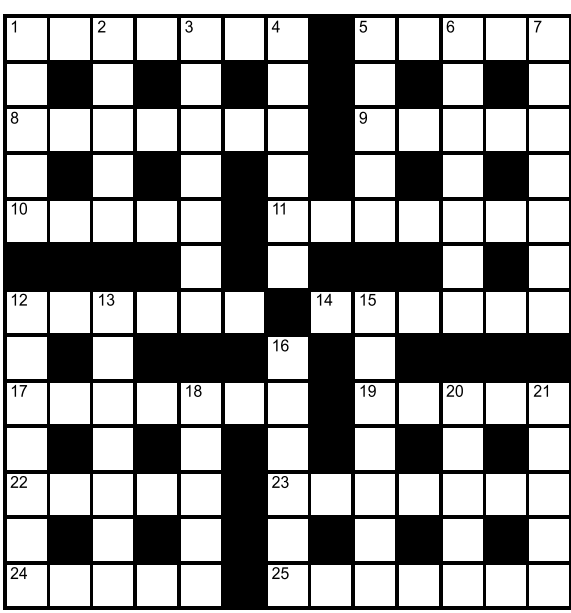
The Little Festival, started by Aysha Rau in 2010, is an international theatre festival for young audiences. “The objective is to bring top-quality productions from all over the world to our city, so children can learn about different cultures and learn to celebrate our differences through stories,” says KK. “At its core, the idea is to further cultivate a sense of empathy, peace and harmony for our society as a whole through the arts,” he adds.

Following the performance in Chennai, *The Kooks* will be performed in Salem, Mumbai, and at a Tamil Theatre festival called Nadagam in Singapore.

“*The Kooks* is universal in its language. The play is designed to speak to all audiences. It will break the barriers of age, language, and ethnicity. With the show travelling to Singapore, it will adapt its minimal verbal format to Tamil and continue to enthrall and entertain the audiences with its spectacular physical humour,” says KK.

The Little Festival is from July 12 to 17, at the Museum Theatre, Egmore. The Kooks will be staged on July 12 at 4pm and on July 13, 14, and 15 at 11am. Giant’s Table will be staged on July 16 and 17 at 11am. Visit @thelittletheatrechennai on Instagram for details.

MP QUICK CROSSWORD 61 (Set by Doppelganger)



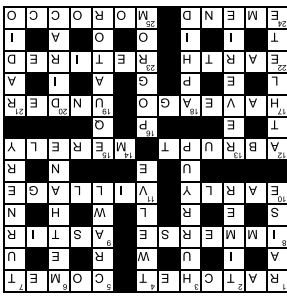
- Across**
- 1 Mechanical device (7)
 - 5 Celestial body (5)
 - 8 Submerge (7)
 - 9 In motion (5)
 - 10 Before time (5)
 - 11 Small town (7)
 - 12 Sudden (6)
 - 14 Only (6)
 - 17 Attempt (4,1,2)
 - 19 Below (5)
 - 22 Surface of the world (5)
 - 23 Withdrawn from office (7)
 - 24 Edit (5)
 - 25 North African country (7)
- Down**
- 1 Erect (5)
 - 2 Chronograph (5)
 - 3 Rush (5,2)
 - 4 Dozen (6)
 - 5 Move on all fours (5)
 - 6 Flammable gas (7)
 - 7 Workshop of lathe operator (7)

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- 12 Sportsperson (7)
- 13 Daydreaming (7)
- 15 Imaginary circle (7)
- 16 Bloodbath (6)
- 18 Plant insect (5)
- 20 Quantum mechanics mathematician (5)
- 21 Wireless communication system (5)

Solution No. 61



Diya Vakada

To read, or not to read, that is the question that has been plaguing me all summer. It is 6am, and there is not a lot that can get me out of bed at this hour, on a Saturday no less. However, I recently banned myself from buying new books until the number matched the pile of books being read. So, in the spirit of turning over a new leaf and pages, I have turned to the reading groups of Chennai to shake me out of this slump.

As I sit under the tower at Anna Nagar Tower Park, blinking away my sleep, people around me have gathered with their books. It is a practice the reading group, Tower Reads, has been keeping up for nearly three years now. Organised by Krishna Kumar, the group comes together under the tower from 6am to 9am every Saturday, bringing their own books to read in the company of others.

“There weren’t many reading groups around when we started, and none that would meet on Saturday,” says Krishna. “This is somewhere people can be in Nature, slow down, and find time for themselves.”

Can you tackle your reading slump with some help from Chennai’s book clubs and silent reading groups?

A novel pursuit

Aside from reading, I stroll around the park, and in an attempt to be social, my question “What are you reading?” is met with various enthused responses. When Chennai remembers that it needs to be unrelentingly hot and sweat begins to drip from my forehead onto the pages of my book, I call it a day.

Despite the pages read, I will admit that this was an extreme way for me to get there. As much as I would like to be the 21-year-old who wakes up at the crack of dawn for some mindful reading, I foresee some struggles in maintaining this



Turning pages Chennai’s reading communities and book clubs come together to help build a habit. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



lifestyle. For the morning people among us, however, I believe that you will find this to be a delightful place with charming company.

My hesitancy to get back into reading also stems from the struggle of choosing the perfect next read. We must deal with the fact that there are just too many books and not enough time to go through them all. Do I finally start reading that copy of *Crime and Punishment* I promise to tackle every summer? Or would something more contemporary be a realistic place to start?

When the Book Club of Chennai choose *Martyr!* by Kaveh Akhbar, a book that has been sitting on my shelf since October last year, I take it

as a sign to make it my next read. Each month, members of the book club vote and choose two books. This time it was the aforementioned *Babel* by RF Kuang. At the end of the month, the members gather in a cafe and discuss the books.

“There are a lot of digital clubs or reading groups,” says Deepanshi Sharma, founder of the book club. “But I wanted to have a community where people read and discuss the same book.”

I find myself making time in the day to finish the book, reading in 20-minute increments as I take the metro, trying not to cry and scare unassuming commuters. While the promised animated discussion does not take place for this month’s books, a new favourite novel seems to have been found.

Book clubs can give incredible new recommendations, but sometimes the book of the month just does not call out to you. In this regard, reading groups might reign supreme. While waking up to read may have proved to be difficult the first time, when the option of coffee is thrown into the mix, I am tempted to try again.

I sit cross-legged at a corner table at the cafe Bask, sipping coffee and

reading. The Quiet Chapter, founded by Rajani Sashikanth, gathers here every Sunday for silent reading sessions. People bring a book of their choice, and between 8am and 10am in Bask’s Kasturi Rangan Road branch and 9am and 11am in the ECR branch, it is time to read. With the books, the food, and the cafe, Bask transforms into a book-lovers haven.

“You have to just walk in with a book, order your coffee or your breakfast and find your spot,” says Rajani, who takes the time to visit every table and chat with the readers. “It’s for people to get back into the habit of reading and to remember what shared silence feels like. No pressure, just come and read with us.”

Chennai’s reading communities are eager to accept all kinds of readers and are worth checking out for anyone who is looking for fun ways to get back into reading. Back to my book, then.

Look up Instagram for more information about joining the groups: @thequiet.chapter; @bookclubofchennai; and @towerreads. No registration is required.



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